

— A FIVE-QUESTION TEST FOR YOUR OWN JOB

# Can this be automated?

Five questions. No code. Ten minutes.

RUN IT ON ONE TASK

- ☒ Does it come back?
- ☒ Are the steps the same?
- ☒ Is the information tidy?
- ☐ Would two people agree?
- ☐ Can you write it down?

answer yes five times · build it    ...    answer yes twice · leave it alone

# Most people automate the wrong thing first

Not because they picked something hard — because they picked something that felt urgent. These are the three traps, and I fell into all of them.

1

## The most annoying one

Irritation is not frequency. The task that makes you sigh the loudest might only happen twice a year.

2

## The most complicated one

Complexity feels impressive to automate. It is also exactly where half-built projects go to die.

3

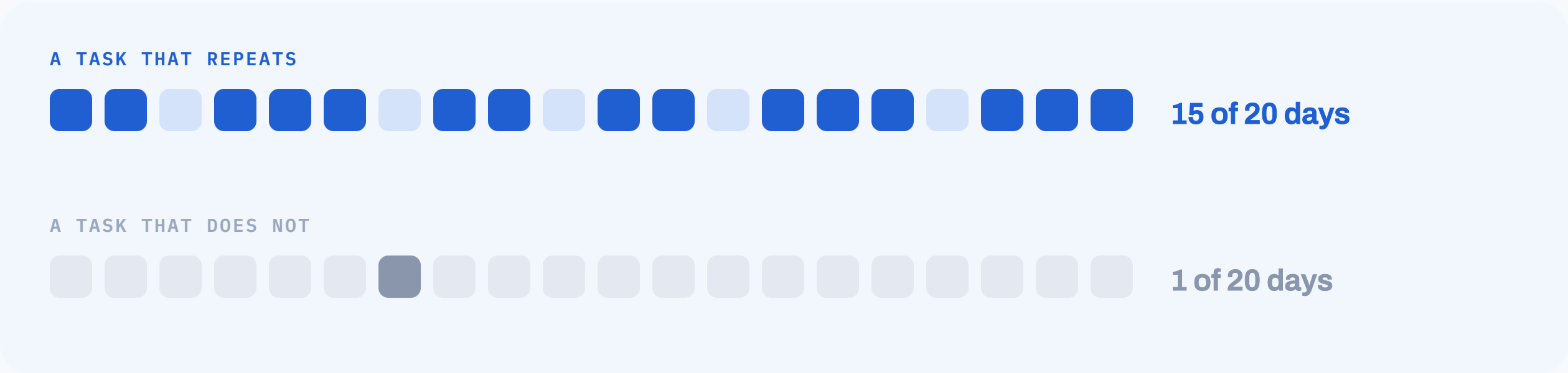
## The one someone asked for

Usually a symptom, not the problem. Ask what they are actually trying to finish, then look one step upstream.

The right first task is boring, frequent, and completely predictable.  
It will not impress anyone. Pick it anyway.

# Does it come back?

Automation pays for itself through repetition. A task you do once a year is not worth a week of building, however much you hate it.



# Are the steps the same?

Not similar — the same. The value is not that the task is easy. The value is that it is predictable, so a machine can follow it without you.

EVERY TIME, THE SAME ORDER

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one set of instructions

EVERY TIME, A DIFFERENT SHAPE

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a new decision each run

GOOD SIGN

✓

You would give a new colleague the same instructions every time.

✓

The order of the steps never changes.

✓

Surprises are rare — and you can name them.

NOT YET

—

It depends who asked, or which client it is for.

—

You handle each one case by case.

—

Half the work is deciding what to do at all.

Predictable beats simple. Long and boring is a perfect candidate.

# Is the information tidy?

Machines are excellent at moving information and poor at guessing what you meant. The tidier it arrives, the cheaper and steadier the build.

arrives as fields

arrives as a paragraph

GOOD SIGN

✓

It arrives as a form, a spreadsheet or a system record.

✓

The same fields sit in the same places every time.

✓

You copy and paste far more than you interpret.

NOT YET

—

It arrives as a paragraph in a chat message.

—

Everyone who sends it formats it differently.

—

You have to read it before you know what to do with it.

Messy input is not a dead end — it is where an AI agent beats a fixed flow.



# Would two people agree?

The test people skip. If two capable colleagues would hand you different results, you are not automating a task — you are automating a decision.



## GOOD SIGN

- ✓ There is a right answer, and you could check it.
- ✓ Two colleagues would hand in the same file.
- ✓ Any argument would be about typos, not opinion.

## NOT YET

- It depends on tone, timing or a relationship.
- You would want a person's name attached to the result.
- Getting it wrong costs money or trust.

Automate the task. Keep the judgement.

# Can you write it down?

Try it now. Write the steps for someone who has never done it. The line where you type "and then you just know" is exactly where automation stops.

- 1

Open the shared inbox
- 2

Find the messages that have an attachment
- 3

Save each file into the right folder
- 4

... and then you just know which ones matter

the sentence where automation stops

## GOOD SIGN

- ✓

You can list the steps in order, start to finish.
- ✓

You know what to do when something is missing.
- ✓

You can name the exceptions out loud.

## NOT YET

- The instructions end in "use your judgement".
- Only one person actually knows how it works.
- It changes every quarter and nobody records it.

If you cannot write it down, you cannot automate it. Write it down anyway.

# Count your yeses

Five questions, five answers. Here is what the total actually means — and what to do about it on Monday morning.

|       |                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 / 5 | <p><b>Build it. This is the one.</b></p> <p>Boring, frequent, predictable and describable. Start here — even while a louder, more annoying task is shouting at you.</p>                 |
| 3–4   | <p><b>Almost. Fix the weak answer first.</b></p> <p>It is usually the shape of the input, or an exception nobody named. Tidy that one thing and the build gets much smaller.</p>        |
| 0–2   | <p><b>Leave it alone — for now.</b></p> <p>Either it is too rare to ever pay back, or the hard part is judgement. That is work for a person — or for an AI agent, not a fixed flow.</p> |



# Start smaller than you think you should

Found one that passed? Four steps, in this order. Most people skip the middle two and then wonder why the build never quite works.

1

## Pick the smallest one

Not the most valuable — the smallest. You are learning the shape of the work, not rescuing the company.

2

## Time it for one week

Write down how long it really takes, every single time. You will be wrong about this, and the real number matters later.

3

## Write every step down

Including the ones you do without thinking. This part takes the longest and teaches you the most.

4

## Build the easy path only

Then watch it break and patch what actually broke. Do not try to imagine every exception up front — you cannot.

Expect to spend more time watching it than building it.  
That is not a failure. That is the job.

## — THE TAKEAWAY

# The hard part was never the tool.

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### **It rewards clear thinking, not clever tools.**

An hour spent choosing the right task saves a week of building the wrong one.

### **You already have the skill that matters.**

If you can explain your job to a new colleague, you can spot what a machine could take.

### **And you can run this test in ten minutes.**

Pick one task from your week. Five questions. See what the answer tells you.

Which task in your week just failed the test?  
That is usually the interesting one.